

FLINTLOCK MUSKETS AND BAYONETS

THE BATTLE OF FONTENOY

The European wars of the mid-18th century were contested with a mixture of formality and savagery. The battle at Fontenoy is a classic example of an era dominated by the musket-volleys of disciplined infantry, manoeuvring with parade-ground precision in spite of heavy casualties.

In 1745, during the War of the Austrian Succession, a French army, commanded by Maurice de Saxe, was campaigning in Flanders. Its opponent, the Pragmatic Army, consisted of Dutch, British, Austrian, and Hanoverian forces under the command of the Duke of Cumberland, son of King George II. Saxe seized the strategic initiative by laying siege to the fortress town of Tournai. The Pragmatic Army had to aid the town, thus allowing Saxe to meet them on a ground of his choosing. He took up a defensive position along a ridge in front of Tournai, anchored by the River Scheldt on his right flank and woods on his left. He fortified two villages, Antoing and Fontenoy, and had five redoubts – earthwork strongpoints – constructed in front of the line. The Pragmatic Army approached Fontenoy on 9 May after an exhausting march. Without having fully appreciated the strength of Saxe's position, the Allied commanders decided to attack on 11 May.

HOLDING THE FIELD

The rival armies were each around 50,000 strong. Aristocratic officers led bodies of mostly professional soldiers, the infantry armed with flintlock musket and bayonet. The French had over 100 cannon, probably more than their opponents, and were also superior in cavalry. The ragmatic Army deployed with the Dutch and Austrians on its left, the Hanoverians and British on the right. The attack began badly. After an ineffectual preliminary bombardment by heavy cannon, frontal infantry assaults against the French right crumbled in the face of withering firepower.

On the French left, the Redoubt of Eu remained intact because the British officer ordered to take it refused to move, apparently unnerved by French skirmishers in the nearby woods.

With the attack having failed to his left and right, Cumberland decided to advance. Urged on, the British infantry marched smartly up the hill between Fontenoy and the intact redoubt. Cannonballs fired from the flanking strongpoints carved gaps in the British ranks, but, undeterred, they progressed to the top of the ridge, bringing them face to face with the opposing infantry. According to the French writer Voltaire, the commanders of the British and French guards each politely called on the other to fire first. There was an end to civilities once the point-blank exchange began, for soldiers fell in heaps, hundreds cut down by a single volley. The British pushed their field guns forward to batter the French with grapeshot, at which point the French line collapsed.

Saxe mustered reserves of infantry and cavalry to launch desperate counterattacks. Having advanced deep into the French position, the British faced assaults from the flanks as well as the front. The Irish Brigade, the "Wild Geese", fighting as mercenaries in the French army, delivered an especially destructive charge. Forced to give way, the British infantry managed an orderly retreat, screened by their cavalry. The French held the field and claimed the victory. The day's fighting had cost some 5,000 lives, with more than twice that number wounded, and many of them maimed for life.

